Surprise Attack - additional player interaction required.

Enabling *deliberately* activated Traps requires one new player interaction:

If a player party including a Dwarf encounters a Trap hazard, then the game pauses, and the player gets a choice as follows:

1. **“Dwarf guides the party past the Trap”.** The Trap remains where it is, and the turn proceeds in this area.
2. **“Dwarf triggers the Trap deliberately”.** The party goes to the area below.

If the Dwarf guides past the trap, but the next hazard is also a Trap, then the party falls down the second Trap unless the party includes two Dwarfs, in which case the choice is presented again.

The game log subsequently contains sufficient information to determine whether a party came down a Trap deliberately. The log already holds sufficient information to determine all of the other conditions outlined in Procedure: Determining Surprise Attack.

I have added the procedure below to may main working document:
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1kwWdsJlAB99vcxwX2Sja38c5P2dkFFzmTs9E3Yjceic/edit?usp=sharing

PROCEDURE: DETERMINING SURPRISE ATTACK

(1) Stranger party attacks:

IF (The player party approaches strangers to test reactions) AND (The strangers prove hostile) THEN (The *strangers* **always** attack with a surprise-attack bonus).

(2) Player party attacks:

When a player party attacks immediately after entering an area containing strangers, they **may** be eligible for a surprise-attack bonus - as follows:

IF (The party arrived by a route that is not navigable in the reverse direction) THEN (The party gets a surprise-attack bonus).

Non reverse navigable routes include:

- Arriving by Magic Carpet.
- Arriving by Sorcerer’s Teleport.
- Arriving by falling into the Whirlpool.
- Descending from The Chasm.

IF (The attacking party arrived this turn via a Trap from the area above that was *triggered deliberately*) THEN (The attacking party gets surprise-attack bonus).

IF (The attacking party arrived this turn via a Trap from the area above that was *not triggered deliberately*) THEN (The attacking party does not get surprise-attack bonus).

IF (The attacking party arrived this turn from a route that is navigable both ways) AND (In the time that this group of strangers has occupied this area, no party has used that route previously - either to enter or to exit the area) THEN (The attacking party gets a surprise-attack bonus).

ELSE:
The attacking party does not get a surprise-attack bonus.

END OF PROCEDURE: DETERMINING SURPRISE ATTACK

{Note: Restricting the search for previous usage of a route to "within the memory of this stranger group" is essential because the stranger may be (for example) a solitary Demon - in which case, in the turn in which it appears, it does not inherit any memory of any player parties previously entering or exiting the area in the past when different strangers occupied it.}

Surprise Attacks - Map Idea:

Just a wild thought: Would it be possible to provide a visual aid to help the player to recall (when it is important) which routes have been used - by placing a door graphic at each chamber or special entrance/exit? (The alphabetic label aspect of the tabletop graphic for secret doors is somewhat redundant in the video game, since each stair is visualised.)

We could perhaps have a set of 3D vertical doors appear each time a *chamber or special* tile is laid (but not secret stair doors until they have been used).

We could use the same graphic as for the "up" route, but 3D.

The door that the party just arrived from is initially presented as a barely-there "ghost" version of the graphic (the door has been "*tentatively*" used, because the party are now stealthily scouting the chamber. But if they immediately withdraw, the door graphic switches back to solid (closed).

If they enter, the door stays in ghost form for the rest of the game.

For Secret Doors, we would have to locate the graphic somewhere near the corners, as now.

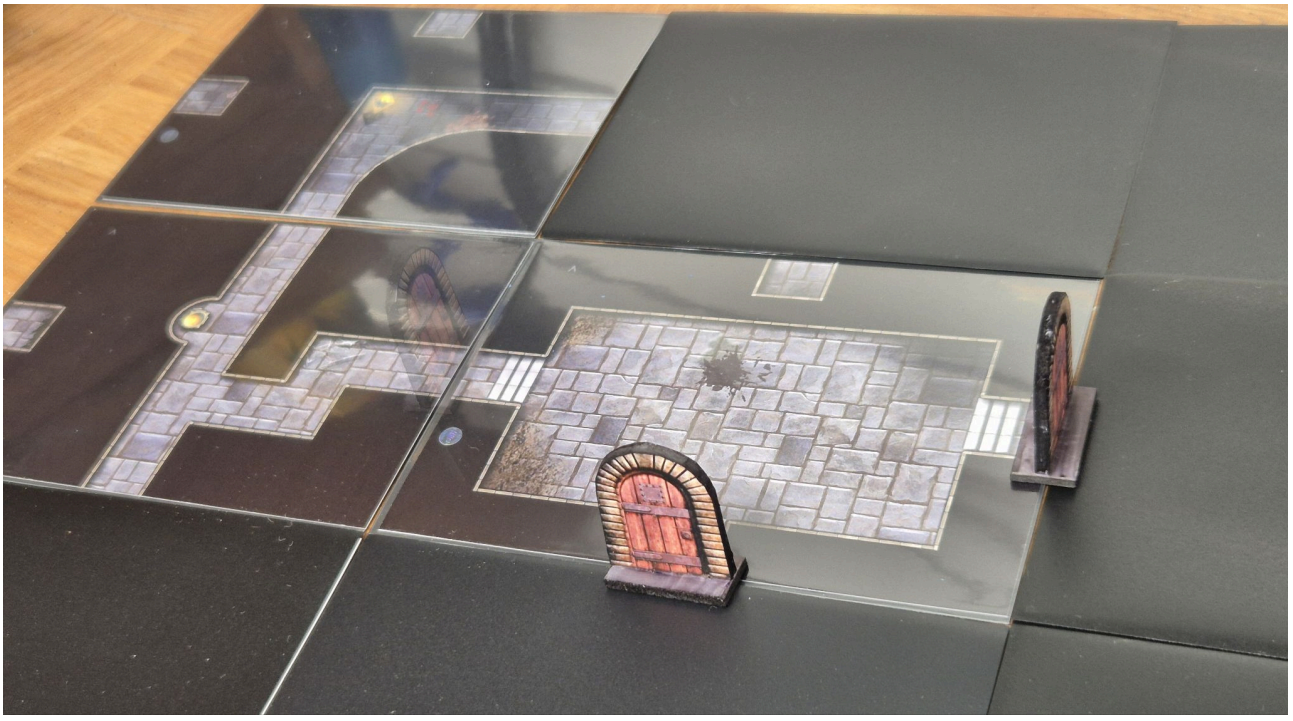
Any unused chamber door would appear solid.

Similarly, when the party uses a door to exit, that door switches to ghosted form.

Thus, the player can clearly see on the map:

(1) Where you entered a chamber but did not interact with it.
(2) Where there are unexplored routes from/to a chamber or special.
(3) Specifically whether any suitable routes are available if the objective is to now surprise-attack a party that were previously approached and proved indifferent sometime earlier in the game.

I made a physical mockup (post processed in PaintShop to “ghost” the entrance door). You have to imagine the pawn is currently sitting in the chamber….



We would have to decide:

- When a tile is laid that connects to a chamber by a previously unused route (solid door) in such a way as to create a dead end *behind* that door, what happens? Should the door automatically disappear? Suggest probably yes - it is redundant now, and suggesting visually that the route is unexplored is pointless…
- If Spell swaps a tile such that a route from a chamber now leads to a different connecting tile, what happens to the door? From the view of strangers in the chamber, and from the player's perspective, that route is still either “used” or “unused” - it is not significant that the strangers don’t know it is now connected differently. The door is either:
    (a) Solid (player *can* enter and surprise-attack from that route)
    (b) Not present (dead end)
    (c) Ghosted (player *cannot* enter and surprise-attack from that route)

Surprise Attacks - In-Game Universe “Fluff”:



Trap

I had been really struggling to identify both a mechanism and an in-game universe credible explanation for “deliberately” falling down a Trap, and the surprise-attack rules. Part of the reason (I now suspect) is that I had a very naive picture in my mind of a “Trap” - basically just a large trapdoor in the floor that, when stepped on, unceremoniously dumps the entire player party down into the chamber below (!)

But I now realize that it makes more sense to think of the dungeon levels as being separated by potentially many feet of rock. A more credible picture of a trap is a bit like this (left).

Stairways and similar routes in the vertical can be quite lengthy and complex. A trap actually dumps the party into an intermediate area in between levels, from where the only way to proceed is to navigate downwards until they reach the chamber below.

But, importantly, all Traps include a warning system which (unless someone tampers with it) alerts any strangers in the area below to the fact that a player party has fallen down the Trap, and their arrival is imminent.



Whirlpool

The in-game universe model of well-separated levels also naturally resolves questions relating to Whirlpool and Chasm.

Whirlpool does not provide a gushing column of water that quickly dumps a wet, bedraggled and confused party into the area below.

Rather, the Whirlpool drops down into a smallish cave containing a shallow pool, from which the water drains out through cracks in the rock.

But there is also a labyrinthine crawlspace leading eventually to the area below. Therefore, a party entering a chamber via Whirlpool from above gets all options as usual, including a surprise-attack bonus in the first round if a fight ensues.



Chasm

Descending the Chasm - similarly - involves first a precipitous drop making it possible to jump down but not climb back up.

At the bottom of the chasm is a small space from which a labyrinth of winding stairs leads eventually to the chamber below.

If strangers occupy the chamber, they have not, and never do, figure out where the multitude of cracks in the rock lead. The way up is not navigable, and the strangers can not set a guard on it.